



Build It From Scratch.

You have a computer. That's it. By the end of this you'll have your own property-lookup tool running on it — built by you, owned by you, costing you nothing to run.

There is **no coding** in here. There is nothing to understand. Every step tells you exactly what to click and exactly what you should see afterwards. If a step doesn't look right, the last page tells you how to fix it.

4 parts

about 15 minutes

Free

nothing to buy today

**No
experience**

none. zero. really.

If you can download a file and click a button, you can finish this. Take one step at a time and don't skip ahead — each step sets up the next one.

What you're actually building.

Read this page once. It's the only page with no clicking in it, and it makes everything else make sense.

Imagine a really good assistant. You give them a street address. They go away and come back with: who owns the house, what it's worth, how much is still owed on it, whether it floods, what rents are nearby, and — if you want — the owner's phone number.

That assistant is what you're building. It's called **OpenProp**, and it will live on your computer and answer to nobody else.

1 The engine

WINDOWS

A free thing called **Python**. It's the motor. It doesn't do anything on its own — OpenProp needs it the way a car needs an engine. **Mac owners already have it** and can skip this part entirely.

2 The tool itself

FREE

OpenProp is a folder of files. You download it, unzip it, and put it on your Desktop. That's the whole "build."

3 Switch it on

FREE

You double-click one file. It opens in your web browser like any website — except it's running on your own machine.

4 Give it eyes (the keys)

OPTIONAL

On its own, the assistant can only see free public info. To see owners and values, you give it "keys" — passwords to the data companies. This part is optional and costs money, so it's last.

Two words you'll see, explained once. A **folder** is just a folder, like any other on your computer. A **key** is a long password you copy from a website and paste into OpenProp — it's how a data company knows it's you asking. That's the entire vocabulary. There isn't any more.

Windows only — Macs already have it. ~3 minutes.

Do you have a Mac? Then Part 1 is already done. Every Mac comes with the engine built in. Don't download anything. Turn the page and start at Part 2. (A Mac is the one with the apple on it. If you're not sure, look for a start button in the bottom-left corner of the screen — if it's there, it's a Windows PC and you should keep reading.)

1

Go and get Python

Open your web browser (Chrome, Edge, whatever you use), click the address bar at the top, and type this in:

➤ python.org/downloads

On the page that opens there's a **big yellow button** near the top that says **Download Python**. Click it. Ignore the numbers after the word "Python" — any version it offers you is fine.

What you'll see: a file arriving in your **Downloads** folder, named something like **python-3.13.exe**. Your browser may show it in a little bar at the bottom of the window.

2

Open it — and tick the box

Double-click that downloaded file. A grey installer window opens.

STOP. Do this before you click anything else.

At the **bottom** of that window there is a small checkbox that says **"Add python.exe to PATH"**. **Tick it.**

It is tiny, it is easy to miss, and it is the single most common thing people get wrong. If you don't tick it, OpenProp will not be able to find the engine and nothing will work later.

Now click **Install Now**. If Windows pops up a box asking "Do you want to allow this app to make changes to your device?", click **Yes**. Then wait — it takes about a minute.

3

Close it and forget it

When the window says **Setup was successful**, click **Close**.

You're done when: the installer says **Setup was successful**. That's it. You will never open Python, look at Python, or think about Python again. It just sits there being an engine.

Engine in. That was the hardest part.

Seriously — everything from here is downloading a folder and double-clicking it.

Get the tool

PART 2

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Download the folder, unzip it, put it on your Desktop. ~3 minutes.

1

Download it

OpenProp lives on a website called GitHub — that's just where people keep code, like a public shelf. Type this into your browser's address bar, exactly as written:

github.com/dweng1572179/fintok-projects

On that page, find the **green button that says "Code"** — right-hand side, just above the list of files. Click it. A small menu drops down. At the bottom of that menu, click **Download ZIP**.

What you'll see: a file called `fintok-projects-main.zip` arriving in your **Downloads** folder. A "ZIP" is just a folder that's been squashed small so it travels faster over the internet. Bought OpenProp instead? Use the link in your email receipt — then skip to Step 3.

2

Unsquash it

Open your **Downloads** folder and **double-click the ZIP file**. That un-squashes it into a normal folder.

ON A MAC

Double-click and you're done — the folder just appears next to the ZIP.

ON WINDOWS

Double-click it, then click **Extract all** at the top of the window, then **Extract**. Don't skip that — Windows will happily let you **look inside** a ZIP without ever unsquashing it, and OpenProp cannot run from in there. If you never clicked "Extract all," you haven't done this step.

What you'll see: a folder named `fintok-projects-main` next to the ZIP file.

3

Find OpenProp inside it, and pull it out

Open that `fintok-projects-main` folder. Inside are **several folders** — other projects that live on the same shelf. You only want one of them.

Find the folder called `openprop` — that one, nothing else — and drag it onto your Desktop. Ignore `web`, `docs`, `local` and `om-builder` completely. They're not part of your tool and they won't hurt anything; they're just not yours to worry about.

You're done when: a folder called `openprop` is on your Desktop, and opening it shows a pile of files — one of them called **Start OpenProp**. That's the one you double-click next. You can bin the ZIP and the big folder now.

You have the tool.

A folder called `openprop` is sitting on your Desktop. Next page: switch it on.

One double-click. Then it's alive. ~4 minutes, mostly waiting.

1

Find the start file

Open the **openprop** folder on your Desktop. Look at the list of files. There's one called **Start OpenProp**. There are two versions of it — use the one for your computer and ignore the other:

Mac **Start OpenProp.command** · Windows **Start OpenProp.bat**

Double-click it.

2

If your Mac blocks it, let it through

Macs are suspicious of files they haven't seen before. If yours says "cannot be opened because it is from an unidentified developer", don't panic — nothing is wrong.

Right-click the **Start OpenProp.command** file → click **Open** → in the box that appears, click **Open** again.

Good news: you only ever do this once, for this one file, forever.

3

Wait for it to build itself

A plain black-and-white window opens with text scrolling in it. **This is normal and you don't have to read any of it.** The first time you ever run it, OpenProp is quietly assembling itself — that takes **1–3 minutes**. Every time after this, it's a couple of seconds.

Leave that window alone. Don't close it. Closing it turns OpenProp off — that's actually how you stop it later, when you want to.

4

Log in

Your web browser opens by itself. If it hasn't after two minutes, open your browser and type this into the address bar:

➤ localhost:8787

"localhost" means **this computer**. You're visiting a website that only exists on your machine — nobody else on earth can open it.

A password box appears. Type the starting password and click **Sign in**:

Password **changeme**



It's alive — and it's yours.

Type any U.S. street address into the box and hit search. You'll get the location, the flood risk, and the neighborhood's income — **free, forever, no keys, no account**. That already works. Go and try it before you read on.

Give it eyes — the keys

PART 4

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Start with none of them. Run the free version for a week and add a key only when you actually miss it.

🔑 What a "key" is, and how you add one

A **key** is a long password you copy from a data company's website and paste into yours — it's how they know it's you asking. You pay them directly, at their price. OpenProp takes no cut.

1. In OpenProp, click **Settings** — small link, very **top-right corner**.
2. **Paste** the key into the box with the matching name, then click **Save**. A **green dot** ● appears. No restart, ever.

The one thing everybody gets wrong: the "Primary property provider" dropdown. Same Settings page, and it must **match the key you pasted**. It arrives set to **reapi**. **Pasted a RentCast key? Change it to **rentcast** and hit Save.** If you don't, your key does nothing and every search comes back empty.

RentCast

~7¢ a lookup · free to try

Start here. Owner name, property details, tax history. Best for looking up **one address at a time**. Sign up at **app.rentcast.io/app/api** → Create API Key → paste it → **set the dropdown to rentcast**. The free plan gives you 50 lookups to play with.

Anthropic (Claude)

~\$5-20/mo · pay as you go

The **AI brain** — lets you search in plain English and writes you a summary of each property. Sign up at **console.anthropic.com**, **buy \$5 of credit first** (the key won't work without it), then API Keys → Create Key → copy it **immediately**, it's only shown once.

HUD & Census

completely free

Local rents and neighborhood income. Free forever, no card. HUD: **huduser.gov/hudapi/public/register** (you **must tick "Fair Market Rents"**). Census: **api.census.gov/data/key_signup.html** (you **must click the email link**, or the key stays dead).

Apify

~10-20¢ each time

The owner's **phone number and email**. Sign up at **console.apify.com/sign-up** → profile picture → Settings → API & Integrations → copy the **Personal API token**. In OpenProp set **Skip-trace vendor = apify**, paste, Save. You only pay when you pull a contact.

RealEstateAPI

free trial, then ~\$600/mo

Only if you want to search a whole zip code and filter by equity or foreclosure — it's the only one that fills in every row. Free trial at **realestateapi.com**. Expensive to keep, so use the trial to find out if you need it.

Don't buy what you haven't already missed. Add RentCast the moment you catch yourself wishing it knew who owned a house — not before. And set the **spending cap** in Settings: OpenProp will refuse to spend past it.

Nothing here is broken.

Everything on this page has happened to everybody. Find your problem on the left, do the thing on the right. Nothing you can do here will damage your computer or lose your work.

The black window flashed up and vanished	Windows: Python isn't installed, or you missed the checkbox. Install it again from python.org/downloads and this time tick " Add python.exe to PATH " at the bottom of the installer before clicking Install. Then double-click Start OpenProp again.
Mac says "unidentified developer" and won't open the file	Expected. Right-click the Start OpenProp file → Open → Open again in the box that appears. Once only, then never again.
The browser says "can't reach this page"	You got there before it did. Wait 30 seconds and refresh. The very first start takes a few minutes. Check the black window is still open — if you closed it, OpenProp turned off; just double-click Start OpenProp again.
Searches come back empty even though I pasted a key	This is the dropdown , 9 times out of 10. Settings → Primary property provider must match your key: RentCast key → rentcast . RealEstateAPI key → reapi . Change it, hit Save , search again.
"No property provider configured"	Same thing as above — OpenProp is looking for a key you haven't given it. Either paste the key for the provider in the dropdown, or change the dropdown to the provider you <i>do</i> have a key for.
My Claude / Anthropic key doesn't work	You almost certainly haven't bought credit yet . Go to console.anthropic.com → Billing → add a card → buy the \$5 minimum. A key with no credit behind it does nothing.
HUD or Census key does nothing	HUD: you must have ticked "Fair Market Rents" when you made the token — if you didn't, make a new one and tick it. Census: you must click the activation link in the email they send you. Un-clicked keys are dead keys.
I want to turn it off	Close the black window — that's it, it's off. Or double-click Stop OpenProp . Your searches, notes and data are all saved and will be there when you start it again.
I think I've broken it beyond repair	You haven't, and you can't. Delete the openprop folder and start Part 2 again. The only thing you'd lose is your saved notes. Nothing on your computer is touched by any of this.



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You built that.

A week ago that sentence would have sounded ridiculous. There is now a piece of real software running on your computer that you set up yourself, that answers only to you, and that nobody can switch off, price-hike, or take away.

It's private

It runs on your machine. Your searches and notes never leave it — there's no company on the other end.

It's yours

No subscription, no seat fee, no expiring credits. You pay the data companies directly, only for what you use.

It's not scary

You just installed an engine, downloaded a folder, and double-clicked a file. That's all "building software" ever was.

Start it any time by double-clicking **Start OpenProp** in the openprop folder on your Desktop. Stop it by closing the black window. That's the whole manual.



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OpenProp — made to be owned, not rented.